One Says Spend It, One Says Move It

A guide to the family conversation about Mom's money: what each of you has been told, done and proposed, on one list.

Your brother heard that Mom's money all has to be spent. Your sister heard it should be moved. Each of them heard it from someone they trust, and you're the one paying the bill.

This guide is for one conversation with one job: put what everyone has been told, has done and is thinking of doing on one list. It isn't for choosing between them.

Who should be there

Mom, wherever she can take part. It's her money, and what she has to say comes first. Her spouse, if she is married. Then everyone who pays a bill for her, helps with her accounts, or has an idea about what should happen with her money. Someone who can't come can send notes ahead.

Pick one person to take notes. It shouldn't be the person leading the conversation.

How to open

Start with what the conversation is for, and say early what it isn't for.

- “Each of us has heard something different about Mom's money. I'd like to get all of it onto one page, so we can take it to someone who knows the rules in her state.”
- “Mom, we'd like your version first: what matters to you, and anything you've already given or promised.”
- “Nobody has to defend what they heard or what they did. We're only writing it down.”
- Say what it isn't for: deciding what to spend, move, sell or buy.

Questions to ask

Ask Mom

1. What matters most to you about your money while you're getting care?

2. Is there anything you've given, lent or promised to someone that we should have on the list?

Ask each other

1. What have you been told about what has to be spent or what should be moved, and who told you?

2. Has anyone paid a bill for Mom out of their own pocket, or been paid back for one?

3. Has anything changed hands or changed names since her care began: a gift, a sale, a car, an account?

4. What are you thinking we should do with her money, even if it's only an idea so far?

5. If Mom is married: what do we know about what her spouse needs at home, in housing, income and savings, and what are we guessing?

6. Which questions do we keep asking each other, such as whether everything really has to be spent, and what don't any of us know yet?

How to write down what was said

Keep three things apart: what someone was told, what has been done, and what is only proposed. Where two people heard different rules, write both and don't settle it. Both go to a professional as they are.

WHAT WAS SAID, DONE OR PROPOSED	WHO	TOLD, DONE OR PROPOSED	THE QUESTION IT RAISES
“It all has to be spent before Medicaid will help.”	David, from a coworker	Told	Is that so in Mom's state, for her situation?
Mom paid Karen back for the furnace repair.	Karen	Done, in the spring	What would a professional want to see about it?
Sell Mom's car.	David	Proposed	What would need to be reviewed first?

What not to decide yet

Each of these depends on Mom's state and her situation, and each is a question for a professional before it is a decision. Your list is what makes that a good conversation. Leave them open.

- What has to be spent, and on what.
- Whether to give, repay, transfer or sell anything.
- Whether to change whose name is on an account or on other property.

- Whether to buy a financial product someone has suggested.
- Who heard the right rule.

What you can decide today

- Who will write up the list and send it to everyone.
- Who will keep the bills and receipts for Mom's care in one place.
- That a new idea about Mom's money goes on the list, with a question beside it, like the others.
- Who will take the list to your Medicaid planner, and who else wants to be in that conversation.
- When you'll talk again.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't settle who heard the right rule, choose between proposals, or tell you what a professional will say. It gets your family to one list, with the differences left on it. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

Your family has one list now: what each of you was told, what has been done and what has been proposed. The planning interview asks about the rest of your situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring, with the list, to your Medicaid planner.

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